Migration Patterns of Young Adults in America

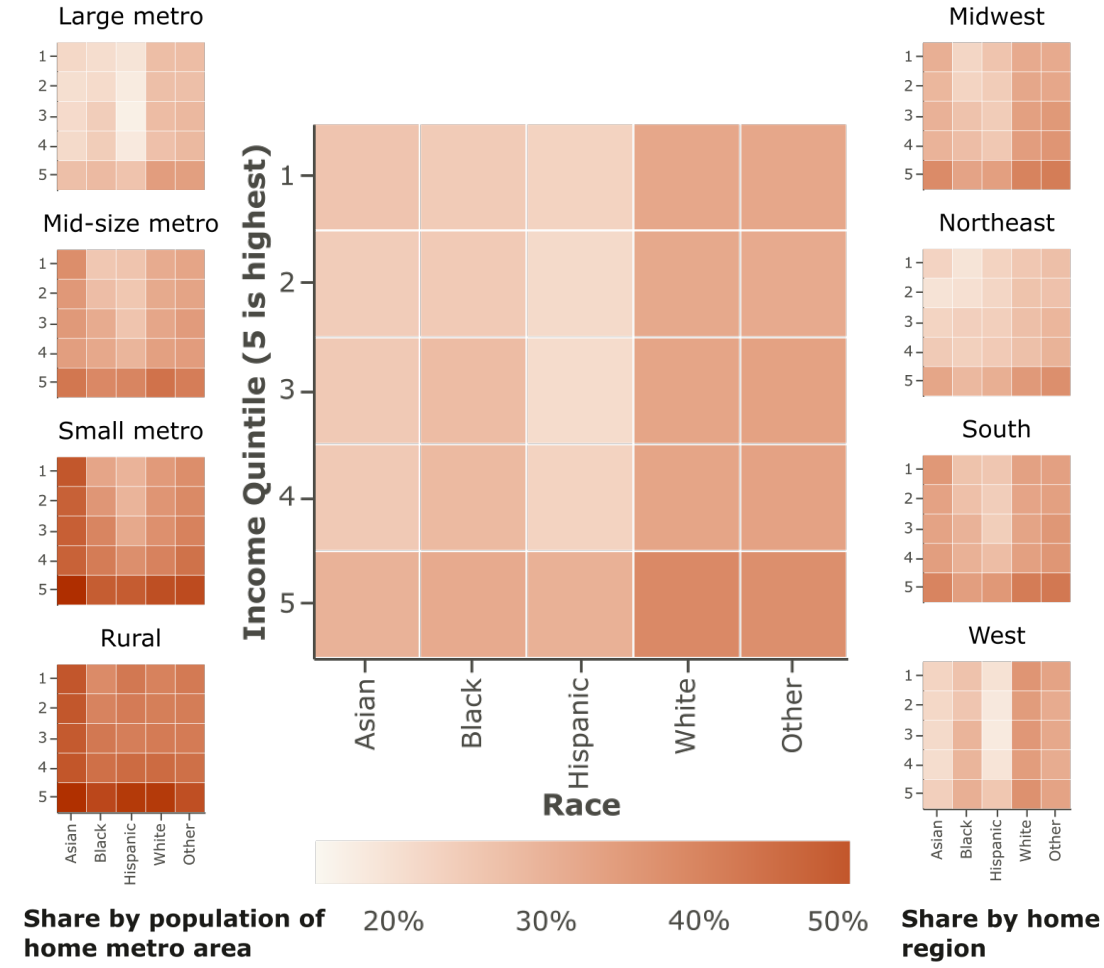
Opportunity Insights at Harvard University used Census Data to track a cohort of children born in 1984-1992 measuring their childhood locations at age 16 and young adult locations at age 36. This infographic uses that data to gain insights into the patterns of the movement of young adults within the United States.

The data is aggregated at the Census Commuting Zone level, which is referred to as "metro area" in the following graphics.

Who leaves home, and where do they go?

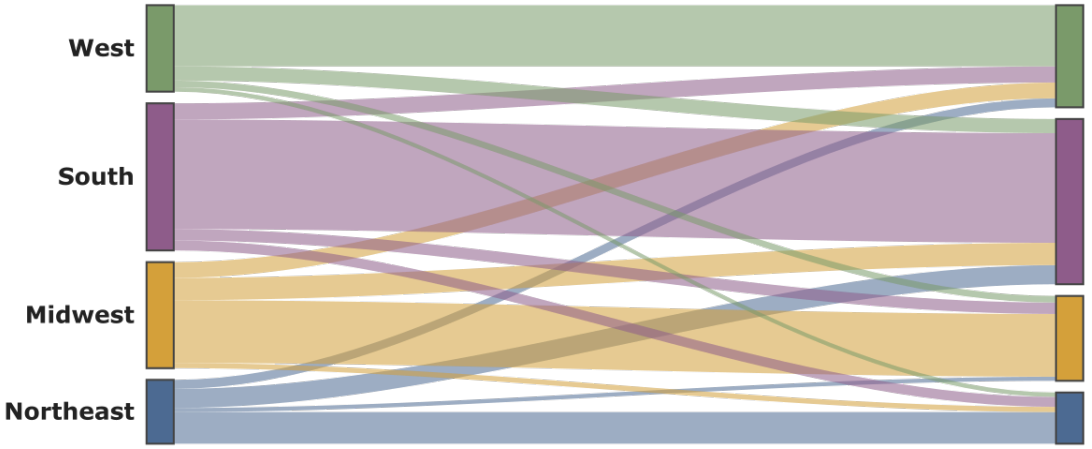
Share of 26-year-olds living outside the metro area they grew up in, by race and parental income

Roughly 31% of all 26-year-olds no longer live where they did when they were 16



Where people live now, by region they grew up in

Left: region of residence at 16. Right: region of residence at 26.



Where people live now, by the population of the metro area they grew up in

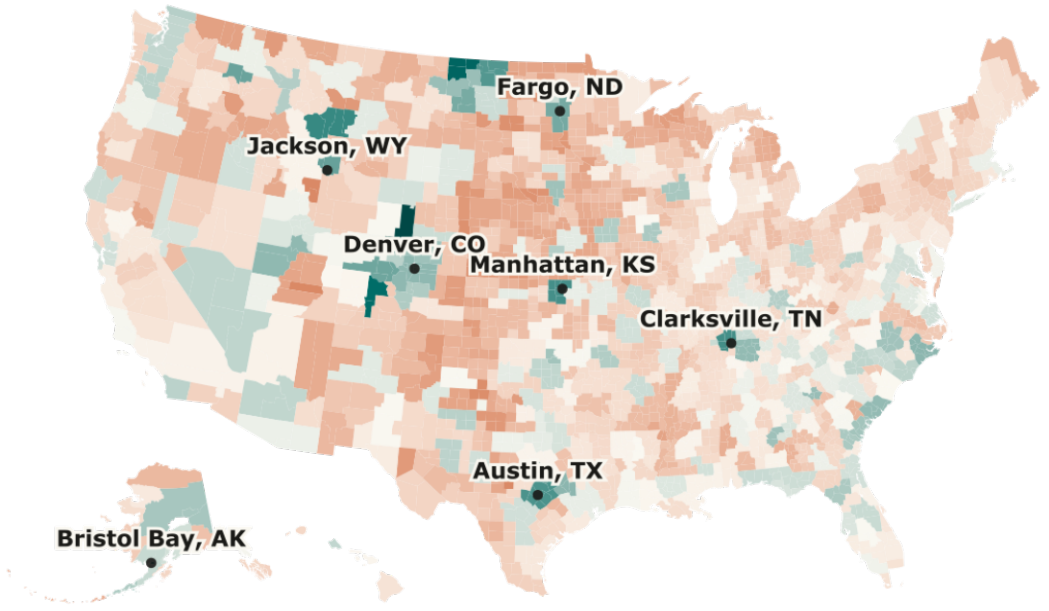
Left: urbanicity of residence at 16. Right: urbanicity of residence at 26.



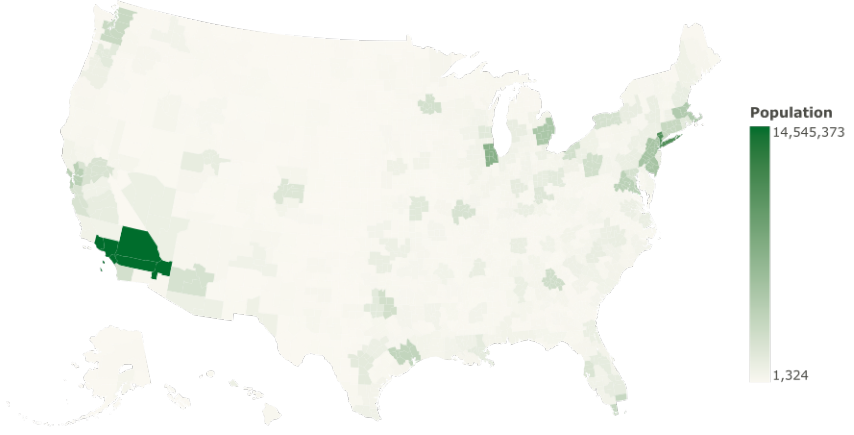
Which Places Gain Young Adults and Which Lose Them?

Percent change in population of people ages 16-26

Counties are colored by the commuting zone they belong to.

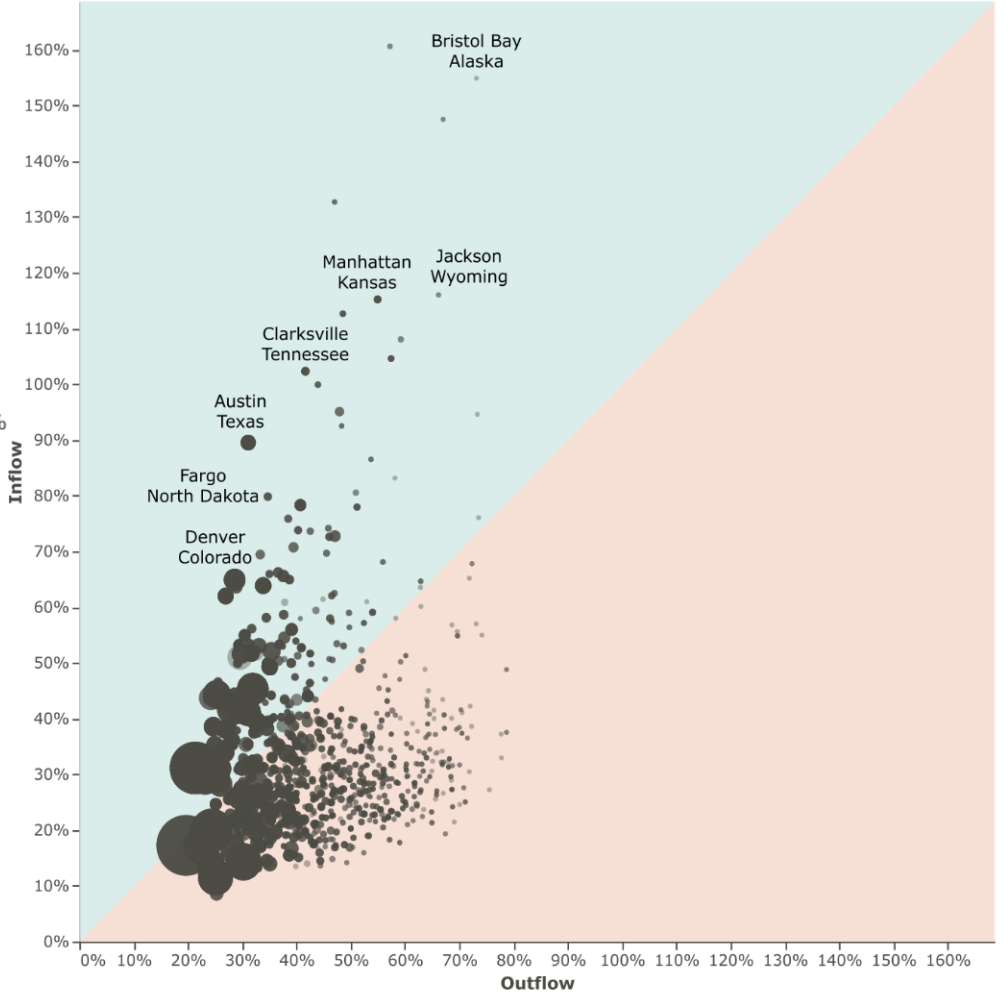


Distribution of population in the US



Young adults moving in and out, sized by total population

Inflow percentage of a metro area is measured as the number of people in the cohort who moved from elsewhere as a share of the number who grew up there.Outflow is the share of people who grew up there who now live somewhere else. Metro areas with higher inflow than outflow have a positive percentage change in population.



Sources:
Sprung-Keyser, B., Hendren, N., & Porter, S. (2022). Migration patterns by race and parental income [Data set]. Opportunity Insights. https://opportunityinsights.org/data/

Sprung-Keyser, B., Hendren, N., & Porter, S. (2022). Aggregate migration patterns [Data set]. Opportunity Insights. https://opportunityinsights.org/data/

U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service. (2012). 1980 and 1990 commuting zones and labor market areas [Data set]. Retrieved 10/16/2026 from https://www.ers.usda.gov/data-products/commuting-zones-and-labor-market-areas